

The Waterfront Brief

Weekly sustainment intelligence for naval shipyard leadership · Naval shipbuilding, ship repair, and fleet sustainment

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Three of this issue's four articles come out of a single document. On August 13 the President sent a memorandum to the Secretary of War whose headline was foreign-built warships, and whose remaining sections order things that land on a waterfront: steam and hydraulics put back into the carrier after next, a fifth public shipyard somewhere near the Pacific Fleet, and a structural review of NAVSEA with its leadership graded on how fast ships come out. Not one of them changes a hull you will touch this year. All of them change what to plan for, and two are aimed at problems the Navy has already reorganised around or already declined to fix once before.

The fourth article has nothing to do with the memorandum and is the most immediately useful thing here: how a printed part becomes a part the Navy will accept, and why that was the difference between eight months and twenty-one days for one destroyer's hangar door.

Labels: FACT is attributed to the named source in the same sentence; Assessment is this desk's analysis, built only on facts stated above it; Speculation is flagged as such; Unverified marks a claim this desk could not check against a primary source, with the reason given.

WATERFRONT OPS & PRODUCTION

Nobody has built a steam catapult since 2009, and the last time this was ordered it did not happen

FACT: the presidential memorandum of August 13, 2026, "Rebuilding the United States Navy and America's Shipbuilding Industrial Base," directs that within 60 days the Secretary of War provide the President "a plan on the required measures to replace the Electromagnetic Aircraft Launch System and Advanced Weapons Elevators with steam and hydraulic systems for the construction of CVN-81, including timelines and resourcing requirements."

EMALS throws aircraft off the bow with a linear motor instead of a steam piston; the Advanced Weapons Elevators lift ordnance on magnetic rails rather than cables. CVN-81 is *Doris Miller*, the fourth Ford-class carrier, still years from assembly.

The ship that shows why sailed nine days before the memo. FACT: USNI News reported on August 12, 2026 that the second Ford-class carrier, *John F. Kennedy* (CVN-79), left Newport News for acceptance trials "after years of delays and Navy and congressionally mandated equipment changes to the ship," and that per budget documents two systems held up its delivery in 2025, one

of them testing on the Advanced Arresting Gear that catches aircraft as they land.

Assessment: so the memorandum proposes to solve on CVN-81 the problem *Kennedy* spent years working through. Whether that is the right engineering call is somebody else's question. What executing it would take is not mainly about catapults.

This was ordered once before. FACT: USNI News reported on May 28, 2019 that the President had called for steam catapults on future carriers, and quoted Bryan Clark, then a senior fellow at the Center for Strategic and Budgetary Assessments, that "the Navy would have to spend several billion dollars to redesign the ship." FACT: the same report states the Navy had spent \$1.3 billion on Ford-class design work per Northrop Grumman's 2006 annual report, and that reverting could not simply reuse Nimitz-class plans, requiring instead a hybrid of the two designs. That reporting is seven years old and is offered as precedent, not as news.

Assessment: so this is not a new idea meeting a new problem. It is a 2019 proposal that did not happen, returning as a directive with a deadline.

Nobody makes these any more. FACT: Navy Lookout reported on August 14, 2026 that USS *George H.W. Bush* (CVN-77), commissioned in 2009, "was the last US carrier built with steam catapults," that "no new sets have been manufactured in almost two decades, so the industrial base that produced the C-13, the steam catapult fitted to the Nimitz class, would have to be reconstituted," and that the White House itself acknowledges reverting would "reactivate portions" of the maritime industrial base. FACT: the same report states that the spaces and infrastructure to support steam catapults, "along with the associated water, condensation and maintenance arrangements," were "deliberately designed out of Ford." FACT: Sandboxx, in an undated article responding to the memorandum, states that "reconstituting a supply chain and re-establishing the human capital necessary to build and install the systems, as well as design a carrier around them, will take time and money."

Assessment: put those together and the shape of the problem changes. Reverting CVN-81 is not waking something dormant. It is reconstituting a vendor base that last delivered a set seventeen years ago, into a shipyard whose supporting spaces were deliberately designed not to have one.

Assessment, and this is the prediction: expect the 60-day plan to be dominated by supplier and workforce timelines rather than by engineering. The C-13 steam

catapult is a mature design that the Navy has operated for decades. What does not obviously exist is a firm that can pour, machine and certify the launch cylinders, or a population of people who have installed and tested a set. That is the long pole, and it is the same category of problem as the castings shortage already gating submarine production, so the honest planning assumption is that it behaves the same way: years, not months, and driven by whether anyone will invest in tooling for an order of three or four sets.

The sailors are fine: one rating already maintains both kinds of catapult. The problem is upstream of them.

Bottom line: treat this as a supplier question, not a manning question. Nothing here changes a ship you will touch this year and the memo may not survive Congress. But if it proceeds, the schedule risk sits with whoever has to pour, machine and certify launch cylinders for the first time in two decades, and that is the same class of constraint already gating submarine castings. If your work plugs into that supplier base, that is where to look for the disruption, not in your qualification pipeline.

Sources: The White House, Aug 13, 2026; USNI News, Aug 12, 2026; USNI News, May 28, 2019; Navy Lookout, Aug 14, 2026; Sandboxx, undated {sources}

The fifth yard's Pacific candidates already have a tenant

FACT: the August 13 memorandum directs that within 120 days the Secretary of War submit a plan to increase submarine and carrier readiness "that will include the use of private sector capabilities and the establishment of a fifth public Navy Yard." FACT: the same section requires that plan to address dry dock capacity for two decades of fast attack submarine growth, "innovative financing mechanisms such as public-private partnerships," and "locations proximate to the United States Pacific Fleet, including in the continental United States, Alaska, Hawaii, and the United States territories."

FACT: the Government Accountability Office, in GAO-20-588, identifies the Navy's four shipyards as Norfolk in Virginia, Pearl Harbor in Hawaii, Portsmouth in Maine and Puget Sound in Washington. Assessment: so naming Hawaii among candidate locations for a *fifth* yard means either a second yard where one already sits, or an expansion of Pearl Harbor described as a new yard.

Guam is where the Navy has already been building.

FACT: the Pacific Island Times reported on September 17, 2023 that the Guam Detachment "was officially approved in December 2019," is "an extension of the Pearl Harbor Naval Shipyard and Intermediate Maintenance Facility," and was established "to close the existing maintenance gaps in executing submarine maintenance in Guam." FACT: the same report states the Navy was hiring more than 570 civilian and military personnel for it at Polaris Point in Piti, most positions requiring nuclear expertise, and that the base is home

port to five nuclear-powered fast attack submarines. That reporting is nearly three years old and stands as dated context, not news.

Assessment: that makes the memorandum's geography legible. Hawaii and the territories are not two alternatives but one relationship, because Pearl Harbor runs the Guam detachment. Speculation: Guam and Alaska are the candidates that make sense on a map, Guam because a Pearl Harbor extension is already standing up against submarines already home-ported there. Nothing has been named: no site, no design, no dock class, no date, which is where this stood when the brief last covered it three issues ago.

And the constraint has not moved. FACT: Breaking Defense reported on August 17, 2026 that Eric Labs, a senior analyst for naval forces and weapons at the Congressional Budget Office, said a fifth yard is "probably talking about something in the \$10 to \$20 billion dollar-range in today's dollars" and would take "at least a decade, maybe more." FACT: the same report quotes Bradley Martin, a senior policy researcher at RAND, that the harder problem is logistical rather than political — "It's more like a practical problem of who you're going to get to come do it" — and that workforce development is "a generation-long thing." FACT: the same report states that Navy data show first-year shipyard employees leaving at 50 to 60 percent, largely over compensation.

Assessment: a first-year attrition rate between half and three fifths is the number that decides this, and it describes the four yards that already exist, not a hypothetical fifth. A new yard staffed at that rate does not staff.

Assessment, and this is the prediction: watch the financing language rather than the map. The memorandum asks for "innovative financing mechanisms such as public-private partnerships" in the same breath as a public yard. Assessment, and this is the assumption the prediction rests on: a public yard staffs from the federal civil service, on pay scales it does not set, which is the same constraint already producing 50 to 60 percent first-year attrition at the four yards that exist. So the plan that comes back in 120 days will most likely lean on contracted labor and private partners for a substantial share of the work, which would make the "fifth public shipyard" a public facility with a largely private workforce. If that is right, the near-term signal is not a groundbreaking or a site announcement. It is a compensation authority, a special salary rate, or a partnering arrangement with a private yard, and any of those would appear long before concrete.

Bottom line: do not plan around a fifth yard; plan around the retention number that will decide whether it can ever be manned. If Guam is where this lands, the near-term signal to watch is not a groundbreaking, it is whether the Pearl Harbor detachment there starts hiring at a scale beyond the figures published in 2023.

Sources: *The White House*, Aug 13, 2026; *Pacific Island Times*, Sep 17, 2023; *Breaking Defense*, Aug 17, 2026; GAO-20-588 {sources}

MAINTENANCE ENGINEERING & TECHNOLOGIES

Eight months or twenty-one days, and the difference is a source approval package

FACT: USNI News reported on June 23, 2026 that the destroyer USS *Halsey* (DDG-97), then with the Theodore Roosevelt Carrier Strike Group, had a broken hangar door, and that sourcing the part conventionally would have taken about eight months and required replacing the entire door. FACT: the same report states that the Navy's Additive Manufacturing Center of Excellence in Danville, Virginia designed a stainless steel bracket that "was built and certified in 21 days using a laser powder bed printer," a machine that fuses metal powder one thin layer at a time, the ship got the part, the strike group deployed, and the technical data package went out to other printers.

Assessment: the interesting number is not 21 days. It is that the technical data package then existed for every other printer, so the second ship with that failure does not repeat the 21 days.

What the capability now is. FACT: the same report states that technical data packages, the complete recipe for a part, "are saved in a secure Navy cloud repository and can be printed, tested, treated and shipped in more than two dozen certified facilities across the country," and that "every big deck amphibious warship has an industrial scale 3D printer aboard." So the design is not regenerated per job, and post-processing is not a separate scramble: the facility that prints the part also tests, treats and ships it.

The route in is public. FACT: NAVSUP Publication NAVSUP-WSS-N23-AM, issued January 17, 2024 and cleared for public release, sets out how a manufacturer becomes an approved source for printed parts: process qualification, a source approval request to NAVSUP Weapon Systems Support, a site survey, then a first article test after award, in which the government verifies the first unit actually matches what was specified. FACT: the same publication states approvals "reflect a risk-based 'consequence-of-failure' approach," and that approval at the second tier is "material and process specific," carrying across to other parts made from the same material by the same process.

What is not solved. FACT: the June 23 report states that wider use of additive parts "is still limited by required Navy certification, contract language and the intellectual property rights of the original equipment manufacturer," that AMCOE is "going through SUBSAFE certification today" with Don Hairston, general manager of Austal USA Advanced Technologies, saying "we're not there today ... but we are on that path," and that

AMCOE and the Navy are negotiating rights for parts designs in the cloud repository, potentially through a licensing agreement. SUBSAFE is the submarine safety programme, the Navy's most demanding quality regime.

Assessment, and this is the prediction: the constraint is legal, not technical, and it does not scale by buying printers. Whoever owns the drawing still owns the part. Expect the complaint in two years to be not "we cannot make it" but "we are not cleared to make it," and watch whether SUBSAFE certification lands at Danville, because that is the test of whether the approval machinery moves as fast as the manufacturing did.

Assessment, second prediction: because approval is bought per material and process, qualification amortizes, and the economics push everyone onto the same few pairs. Good for whoever stands on a common one, bad for whoever qualified something unusual.

Bottom line: the material-and-process tier is the thing to buy, not the part, because one approval covers every part sharing that pair. Before spending on qualification, ask NAVSUP Weapon Systems Support which material and process combinations the certified network already runs, because that list decides whether your qualification is an asset or an island. This desk could not establish that list from public sources, and it is the first question worth asking.

Sources: *USNI News*, Jun 23, 2026; *NAVSUP Publication NAVSUP-WSS-N23-AM*, Jan 17, 2024 {sources}

BUSINESS PRACTICES & STRATEGY

The memo tells NAVSEA to stop redesigning things, and grades its leaders on delivery speed

FACT: the August 13 memorandum directs that within 120 days the Secretary of War submit "a review of NAVSEA, including recommendations for implementing personnel, organizational, and structural reforms," whose objectives should be to "introduce results-based accountability for NAVSEA leadership, determined by speed of delivery of vessels and systems; reduce bureaucracy and red tape; eliminate competing priorities among different NAVSEA components, which often result in delayed, cost-prohibitive, or overly complex vessels and systems; and prevent NAVSEA from imposing redesigns or iterative design changes upon original mature parent designs."

FACT: the same memorandum separately directs, for the ship programs bought under its new foreign-supplier model, that "the Navy shall not impose iterative design changes upon the original mature parent designs," with no change permitted without the approval of the Secretary of War, in consultation with the Secretary of the Navy, the budget director and the President's national security adviser.

NAVSEA was reorganised five months before this ordered a review of it. FACT: the Department of the Navy announced on March 16, 2026 the establishment

of five Portfolio Acquisition Executive organisations: PAE Industrial Operations, Marine Corps, Maritime, Strategic Systems Programs and Undersea. FACT: USNI News reported the same day that PAE Industrial Operations “will oversee maintenance and the public shipyards,” and quoted Vice Adm. Seiko Okano, the principal military deputy to the assistant secretary for research, development and acquisition, that “about 70 percent of the functions and the workforce at our systems commands like NAVSEA will transfer to the PAEs.”

Assessment: so the memorandum orders a 120-day review recommending structural reform of a command that had roughly seven tenths of its functions and people moved out five months earlier. The thing being reviewed is not the thing that existed when the problem was diagnosed.

Assessment: the same instruction appears twice in one document, aimed once at a procurement model and once at an organization, which says what the drafters thought the problem was. NAVSEA has been the technical authority for a yard, owning the specifications work is written to and approving departures from them. Telling it to stop imposing design changes is telling it to exercise less of the function it exists to perform. **Unverified:** after a transfer of roughly 70 percent of functions and workforce to the PAEs, this desk could not establish from public sources whether technical authority moved with them or stayed, and that is precisely the question a yard needs answered. For a yard the stake is concrete, because design churn is how a package grows after it is planned, and the cost is rarely the change itself but the resequencing around it.

Assessment: the risk sits in the measure. A technical authority graded on delivery speed has one obvious lever, which is to approve faster, and a single speed metric cannot tell bureaucracy apart from a specification holding a line on a system that will be at sea for forty years.

Assessment, and this is the prediction that matters most for a waterfront: design changes do not stop being needed because an organization is told to stop making them. Ships still meet conditions their drawings did not anticipate. If NAVSEA is barred from imposing changes on mature parent designs, and is simultaneously being graded on delivery speed, then the pressure does not vanish; it relocates. The likely destination is downward, into departures from specification, field changes and

liberalized waivers handled at the activity rather than the command. That is the same design churn, relocated to where a yard absorbs it directly.

Assessment, second prediction: expect approvals to get faster before anything gets better. A departure granted quickly is cheap on the day and expensive in a later availability, and the gap between the two is long enough that nobody connects them. FACT: GAO reported in GAO-25-106749 that on cruiser modernisation “the Navy has yet to identify the root causes of unplanned work,” and that the Navy concurred with its recommendation to assess those root causes and codify mitigation in policy. Assessment: an organisation that cannot yet attribute its unplanned work is not positioned to notice when a faster approval today becomes rework later. If you are running the job, keep your own record of what you were allowed to depart from and why, because the command’s file will show a fast approval and yours will need to show the condition that justified it.

Reading variation. Assessment: whatever measure emerges, a single quarter of faster deliveries will not tell anyone whether this worked. Delivery dates move for reasons that have nothing to do with NAVSEA’s approval behavior, and reacting to one reading as though it were a trend is how a process gets made worse by people trying to improve it.

Bottom line: watch what your technical authority is being measured on, because it will change what you can get approved and how fast. If the 120-day review lands as written, expect faster answers on departures and changes, and expect to have to be more careful yourself about which departures you ask for, because the pressure to say yes will be sitting on the other side of the desk.

Sources: The White House, Aug 13, 2026; U.S. Navy, Mar 16, 2026; USNI News, Mar 16, 2026; GAO-25-106749, Dec 17, 2024 {sources}

The Waterfront Brief is compiled weekly by the B2 vault’s research engine, this week by hand and without the automated gather, from the presidential memorandum of August 13, USNI News, Breaking Defense, GAO, NAVSUP and NAVSEA publications and regional press (37 sources staged this week; one article cut and its research parked for a later special issue), then synthesized and labeled by hand. Scope: US shipbuilding, US Navy sustainment, and partners across the Indo-Pacific region; out-of-area items only for a direct, stated lesson. Freshness policy: every article’s anchor source is under 12 months old; anything older appears only as dated context or a flagged exception, and standards and regulations are cited as current text rather than news. FACT means the named source says it, not that this desk has independently verified it. Corrections welcome; the staged sources are retained for audit.

UPCOMING EVENTS

Nearest first, filling the page (dates and registration deadlines exactly as organizers publish them). **Bold** marks a decision that closes inside the next 60 days. NSRP is the National Shipbuilding Research Program, the industry-and-Navy body that funds shared shipyard process research; ASNE is the American Society of Naval Engineers; NCMS is the National Center for Manufacturing Sciences; SME is the Society of Manufacturing Engineers.

Dates	Event	Register by	Why it matters
Aug 24-25, 2026	NSRP Workforce & Compliance Panel Meeting, Institute for Human & Machine Cognition, Pensacola, FL (NSRP)	In-person closed Aug 13, 2026 (per page)	Workforce pipeline: cross-yard workforce practices while the Navy chases its 250,000-hire target
Aug 25-27, 2026	PSNS & IMF Sustainment Accelerator, Kitsap Conference Center, Bremerton, WA (NCMS with Puget Sound Naval Shipyard & IMF)	Not published	Maintenance technology adoption: the shipyard published its own Desired Capabilities list for this event: non-destructive testing and inspection, welding solutions, portable power and machining tools, 3D scanning and metrology, confined-space monitoring, human augmentation, fibre-optic splicing, and unmanned systems. A public yard naming the gaps it will be sold on.
Sep 22-24, 2026	Fleet Maintenance & Modernization Symposium (FMMS) 2026, Virginia Beach Convention Center, Virginia Beach, VA (ASNE)	Early bird closed 08/16/26 (per ASNE rate table)	Maintenance execution / regional capacity: the flagship fleet maintenance and modernization event for exactly this readership
Sep 29 - Oct 2, 2026	SCA Fall Membership Meeting 2026, Washington, DC (Shipbuilders Council of America)	Members only; none published	Policy engagement / contracting structures: the surface-repair industrial base's Hill-and-Navy engagement window
Oct 28-29, 2026	Arctic Operations Symposium 2026, Maritime Institute of Technology, Baltimore, MD (ASNE)	Not published yet	Regional capacity: cold-region sustainment, hull and machinery readiness
Nov 16-17, 2026	Navy Procurement Outlook Summit, Carahsoft Conference Center, Reston, VA (Defense Leadership Forum)	Eventbrite open; no deadline published	Contracting structures: shipbuilding-plan and post-consolidation procurement priorities, with contracting-officer access; billed as the 2027 outlook
Dec 7-9, 2026	Technology, Systems & Ships / Combat Systems Symposium, George Mason University, Arlington, VA (ASNE)	Not published yet	Maintenance execution: technology, systems and ships exchange near the NAVSEA customer

On the registry beyond the 365-day window, rolling in as they approach: Indo Pacific 2027 International Maritime Exposition (Nov 2-4, 2027).